Album Studio · Tools Bar

Retouch panel manual

Portrait retouching from the Tools Bar: dodge & burn, skin smoothing, blemish work, and makeup layers: one click each, executed inside Photoshop on the document you are working on. These are the studio's proven retouching actions, carried over intact from the original 2018 Photoshop panel.

Creative Hubb Album Toolkit Pro · July 2026 edition

1 · Getting started

Open the Tools Bar from the **Tools** tab in Album Studio (**Open Tools Bar**). The bar docks itself to the bottom edge of the Photoshop window and follows it around. Click **Retouch** in the bar to open the panel; click it again (or press **Esc**) to close it.

Everything in the panel acts on the **active document in Photoshop**. You need:

- Photoshop running, with the document you want to retouch frontmost;
- the default `Soft Round` and `Hard Round` brush presets present (tools select them by name);
- for the intensity sliders and level pills: the matching setup tool run first (each section below says which).

The panel runs one tool at a time. While a tool executes, the panel dims briefly and a toast reports the result (✓ on success, the Photoshop error message otherwise). The panel stays open while you paint, so you can keep adjusting intensity without reopening it.

Save first: several tools flatten.
Every tool in the Skin and Makeup sections starts by flattening the document. That is by design (the original panel worked the same way), but it means layered work collapses. Duplicate the document (Image → Duplicate) or save a layered copy before a skin or makeup pass. Each tool's steps land in Photoshop's History panel, so an entire tool run can be stepped back, though History only reaches as far as its state count allows.

2 · Dodge & burn

Dodging (lightening) and burning (darkening) shape a portrait: brighten the eyes and highlight side of the face, deepen shadows and contours. The panel offers two setups: a fast automatic one and a paint-it-yourself manual one.

Auto setup

Creates a group named `Automatic Dodge and Burn` holding two curves adjustment layers:

Layer	Curve	Tone limit (Blend If)	Effect
`Dodge`	lifts midtones (104 → 180)	fades out of the shadows	brightens the lighter half of the image
`Burn`	lowers midtones (151 → 76)	fades out of the highlights	deepens the darker half of the image

The effect is immediate and global: the Blend If limits keep each curve on its own side of the tonal range, so contrast builds without crossing over. From there, shape it:

1. Drag the **Dodge** and **Burn** sliders to taste; they set each layer's opacity (10–100%). Start low: 20–40%.
2. To keep the effect off an area (skin you have already balanced, a bright dress), click **Dodge** or **Burn** in the panel to target that layer, then paint its mask with black at low brush opacity.

Manual setup

Creates a group named `Dodge and Burn` with the same two curves layers, but their masks are **inverted (filled black)**, so nothing changes until you paint. It also selects the `Soft Round` brush and sets white as the foreground color, ready to go:

1. Run **Manual setup**.
2. Click **Dodge** in the panel (targets the Dodge layer, resets colors; press **X** in Photoshop so white is on top). Set brush opacity to 5–15%.
3. Paint where the light should build: tops of cheekbones, bridge of the nose, catchlights under the brows.
4. Click **Burn** and paint the contours: under the jaw, sides of the nose, the hairline.
5. Balance the pass with the two intensity sliders.
6. When the pass is done, click **Finish manual pass**: it stamps the visible image and merges it with the group into a single layer named `Dodge & Burn`.

Build in whispers.
Ten strokes at 8% opacity always beat one stroke at 80%. Zoom out often; dodge & burn reads at viewing distance, not at 200%.

“Layer Dodge is not available”?

The **Dodge**/**Burn** buttons and both sliders look for layers named `Dodge` / `Burn`. Run one of the two setups first (or rename your own layers to match and they will work too).

3 · Skin

A frequency-based smoothing layer you paint in exactly where you want it, adjustable after the fact, plus a dedicated layer for blemish work.

Retouching layer

Flattens the document, then builds a smart-object layer named `Advanced Skin Retouching`: a copy of the image, inverted, set to Overlay, carrying two smart filters: High Pass 5 px and Gaussian Blur 1 px. The layer gets a **hide-all (black) mask**, and the `Soft Round` brush is selected with colors reset.

1. Run **Retouching layer**. Nothing visibly changes yet, because the mask hides it.
2. Press **X** so white is the foreground; brush opacity 30–50%.
3. Paint over skin: cheeks, forehead, chin, neck. Skip the eyes, brows, lips, nostril edges, and the hairline. Softening those reads instantly as retouched.
4. Tune the strength with the **Smoothing** pills and the amount of surviving pore texture with the **Texture** pills (below).

Smoothing & Texture pills

Both rows re-dial the smart filters on the `Advanced Skin Retouching` layer, so that layer must be the **active layer** in Photoshop when you click a pill (it already is, right after setup). Nothing is rebuilt, so you can switch levels freely and compare.

Pill	Smoothing (High Pass)	Texture (Gaussian Blur)
Low	1 px	1 px
Low+	3 px	3 px
Med	5 px (the setup default)	5 px
High	7 px	7 px
High+	10 px	10 px
Max	20 px (“Insane” in the original panel)	–

Smoothing sets how large an imperfection gets evened out: higher radius, stronger smoothing. **Texture** excludes detail finer than its radius from the correction: higher values let more natural grain survive, keeping skin from going plastic. The setup default (Med / 1 px) suits most close portraits; go gentler for tight head shots, stronger for full-length shots where skin is small in frame.

Blemish layer

Flattens the document and adds an empty layer named `Blemish Removal Layer`, sets the foreground color to pure red, and selects the `Hard Round` paintbrush. Two ways the studio uses it:

- **Marking pass:** dot every blemish in red at 100% zoom, hand the file (or your future self) an exact to-heal list, then delete the layer when the healing is done.
- **Non-destructive healing:** keep the empty layer targeted, switch to the Spot Healing Brush with **Sample All Layers** on, and heal onto it, keeping the fixes separate from the image.

4 · Makeup

Five paint-on layers for color work. Each tool flattens the document, adds an empty layer with the right blend mode, and selects the `Soft Round` brush; you choose a foreground color and paint.

Tool	Layer it creates	Blend mode	Paint
Blush-on layer	`Blushon Layer`	Overlay	the cheeks
Eye color layer	`Eye Color Layer`	Color	the iris only
Eyeshade layer	`Eyeshade Layer`	Overlay	the lids, below the brow
Hair color layer	`Hair Color Layer`	Overlay	the hair, avoiding the part line
Lipstick layer	`Lipstick`	Overlay	the lips, inside the lip line

1. Run the tool, then pick a foreground color in Photoshop (sample from a reference if you have one).
2. Paint at 15–30% brush opacity and build up. Overlay multiplies contrast as well as color, so less is more.
3. Trim the result with the layer's opacity, and erase (or mask) spill: color on teeth, skin, or the whites of the eyes gives the game away immediately.

Eye color uses Color mode deliberately.
It replaces hue and saturation but keeps the iris's own luminance and structure, so pick a saturated foreground and let the natural fibers of the iris show through.

5 · Troubleshooting

Symptom	Cause & fix
"No document open in Photoshop"	The panel needs an active document; open (or click into) the file first.
"The object … `Dodge` / `Burn` … is not available"	The intensity sliders and the **Dodge/Burn** buttons need those layers to exist. Run **Auto setup** or **Manual setup** first.
Smoothing / Texture pill fails	The `Advanced Skin Retouching` layer must be the active layer, and it must still be the smart object built by **Retouching layer**. click it in the Layers panel and try again.
" `Soft Round` / `Hard Round` … is not available"	Those default brush presets were removed or renamed. Restore defaults via the brush preset menu (or add presets with those names).
First run is slow	The Photoshop bridge warms up on its first call of the session; subsequent runs are near-instant.
Panel ignores clicks	A tool is still running (the panel dims while busy). Wait for its toast. If Photoshop is showing a modal dialog, dismiss it; scripts cannot run behind one.
Buttons do nothing / bar gone	The Tools Bar hides when Photoshop minimizes and closes with it. Reopen from the **Tools** tab in Album Studio.

6 · Quick reference

Button	Flattens?	What it does
Auto setup	no	Adds the `Automatic Dodge and Burn` group; instant, tone-limited contrast shaping
Manual setup	no	Adds the `Dodge and Burn` group with hidden masks; brush ready to paint
Finish manual pass	no	Stamps the visible image and merges the pass into one `Dodge & Burn` layer
Dodge / Burn	no	Targets that layer and resets colors, ready to paint its mask
Dodge / Burn sliders	no	Sets that layer's opacity (applies when you release the slider)
Retouching layer	**yes**	Builds the `Advanced Skin Retouching` smart object with a hidden mask
Smoothing / Texture pills	no	Re-dials the High Pass / Gaussian Blur smart filters on that layer
Blemish layer	**yes**	Empty `Blemish Removal Layer`, red foreground, hard round brush
Makeup tools (all five)	**yes**	Empty color layer with the right blend mode, soft round brush selected